

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



Rallying for Support

JAIPUR With election year round the corner politicians have suddenly emerged out of their shell and are brimming with innovative ideas and promises. A few weeks ago, Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje demonstrated that Rajputs were with her by addressing a massive social gathering. She followed this up with a Jat rally on February 13 where former Congress leader Natwar Singh

shared the dais with her. Singh was suspended from the Congress following charges of helping his son Jagat Singh get contracts in the oil-for-food programme in Iraq.

BSP has been trying to make inroads into the state for long with the support of insignificant leaders of all castes. On February 17 in Jaipur, BSP chief and Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati touched the nerve of the ongoing caste dilemma

IN ARMS: Natwar Singh (left) and Raje

which both the Congress and the BJP are facing in the face of Gujjars demanding Scheduled Tribe status. She promised to fulfil this demand of the community and became the first non-Gujjar leader of a political party to categorically announce this as an election sop.

To counter any backlash from the Meenas who are opposed to the Gujjars's demand and are not amongst Mayawati's votebank, she promised to increase the reservation quota of Scheduled Tribe so that the Meenas' share is not affected. However, Gujar leaders did not lap up the offer and were quick to ask Mayawati to enter into a poll alliance with them if she wanted their votes.

Not to be left out, the Congress, which is comparatively quiet on agitational politics and rallies, boycotted Governor S.K. Singh's address and stalled the House on the issue of appointments of parliamentary secretaries in excess to the number of ministries. **by Rohit Parihar**

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: National Securities Depository Limited chairman **Chandrasekhar Bhaskar Bhawe** as chairman of the Securities and Exchange Board of India. He succeeds M. Damodaran.

WON: By **Samaresh Jung** (pic) and **P. T. Raghunath**, gold



medals at the Hungarian Open in the men's air rifle matches. **Suma Shirur**

won the gold in the women's air rifle category.

CONVICTED: By a Patna CBI special court, Rashtriya Janata Dal MP Rajesh Ranjan alias **Pappu Yadav** and former MLA **Rajan Tiwari** for the murder of CPI(M) MLA Ajit Sarkar and two others on June 14, 1998.

WON: By **Rajiv Ouseph**, 21, the men's singles at the English National Championships in Manchester. He is the first badminton player of Indian origin to have won the title.

VIS-A-VIS **LALU PRASAD YADAV** RJD chief **versus** **AMAR SINGH** Samajwadi Party general secretary

I will show the might of the people from Bihar and UP by performing Chhath Puja in front of Raj Thackeray's house.



Lalu talks about puja outside Raj's house. Next he will want to perform it in his bedroom. These are provocative remarks.

EPILOGUE: When have politicians done anything but pass provocative remarks against each other?